

SEPTEMBER 2023



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POLITICS

The First Dictator

A re-examination of Julius Caesar beyond Shakespeare's romantic portrayal — the general who conquered the Gallic tribes by exploiting their internal divisions, triggered a civil war, and earned enough enemies to be stabbed twenty-three times by his own colleagues.

BY MOULI SHARMA

19 SEPTEMBER 2023 · 3 MIN READ



ABOUT

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LOCATION

New Delhi, India

INDEPENDENT • VOLUNTEER-RUN

VOL. 18 • EST. 2022

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Julius Caesar and His Many Jeopardies



I first came across the name, Julius Caesar, while flitting through the pages of my middle school textbook three quarters of a decade ago. The great Roman ruler, romanticized in the words of Shakespeare, painted a somewhat sympathetic picture in my mind. A man slayed by his own; how could one not feel pity? I was young and impressionable, taking William's affinity for drama to be mortal truth. Julius therefore did enjoy a high position (heh) in my mind for a couple of years. Now that I am older, I feel obligated to hold myself accountable.

Outside of fiction, Julius Caesar was just a General who later became Rome's self-proclaimed elected leader. His troops marched forward to conquer the Gallic Tribes while mercilessly exploiting tribal rivalries. It inevitably led to the infamous and much talked about Civil War between Caesar's gallant forces and his arch nemesis, Pompey. While Caesar emerged victorious, he reserved for himself a feeling of hatred in the hearts of many. Enough for those many to plot his downfall and eventually ensure it. He tasted the sweet fruit of victory but - as they say in middle school English textbooks - alas, he couldn't enjoy it.

A mere 5 years into the rule, he was assassinated with a dagger (🗡 then several more) through the heart by those he trusted most. And the question that both thespians & newsreaders of 44 BC have deigned to haunt us with forever, is did he deserve it?

What comes to mind when hearing the word 'Dictator' is normatively defined. Cruel, evil, merciless - the worst person ever. But its etymology is fairly neutral. It derives, obviously, from the term 'dictate,' i.e. 'to tell someone what to do.' A dictator as a political role then, in essence, is little more than managerial. Its only association to popular history is that the exemplary work of dictators like Stalin, Hitler, and Kim Jong-Un has managed to paint a prevailing mindset that dictators are inherently awful and malevolent individuals, and that much is fine. But then you see Mustafa Kemal, fondly known as Atatürk - '*father of the Turks*,' a revolutionary nationalist who rose against the Ottoman Empire in the early 20th century and led Turkey on a path of modernization. You see Lee Kuan Yew, who led Singapore to independence from British rule in 1959 and elevated its agricultural economy to new heights, laying the foundation for Singapore to become one of Asia's wealthiest countries. You see more & you read more & you're forced to ask - what gives?

The modern Geo-political world has afforded too much importance to words and labels. A young girl who likes video games becomes an NLOG becomes a Pick-Me. A terrorist becomes a Prime Minister becomes a Gold Medalist becomes a World Leader. A CEO becomes a Genius becomes Revolutionary becomes a Meme. Invaders become Natives become Civilized become Developed. The Indian state of Allahabad becomes the *Bharatiya* state of *Prayagraj*. It seems that nouns, even proper ones, now carry the potential to alter the course of history.

Perhaps, before anything else, the dictator is a victim of semiotics. Which of our polities is a democracy & which a dictatorship is perhaps more a function of aesthetics than it ever was of social science. Perhaps Caesar wasn't the first dictator, so much as he was simply the first so called, and *perhaps* (perhaps), this is what Shakespeare meant, when he asked what is in a name.

| Proposed by Kashvi Basu, *The Voice Express*.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



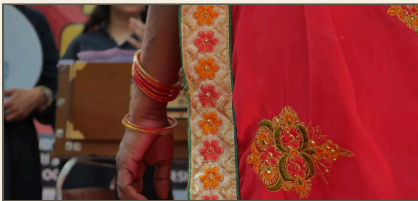
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Mouli Sharma is a journalist, freelance illustrator, and writer from New Delhi, India. She is a published photojournalist & illustrator, having been featured in The Hindu College Gazette, & the quarterly Pink Disco. Mouli took over as the Editor of The Voice Express (<https://thevoiceexpress.github.io/e-mag/>) back in September 2023.

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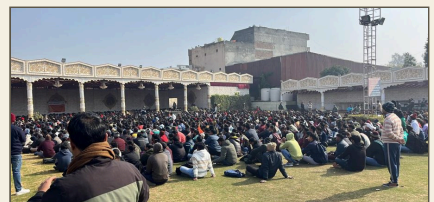
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